Westbrook School Committee

~ Finance Committee Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, March 4, 2026
Time: 5:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1170439612
Packet: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1wGkdwxR68In_XCduVWHu4WdH9imJpf7C/view (Google Drive, via westbrookschools.org)

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *This was the FY27 budget season's opening Finance Committee meeting; per standing practice, the full School Committee sat as the committee of the whole. No votes were taken — this was the first of several weeks of budget presentation and review. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Energy Efficiency Update & Monthly Financials

Siemens Energy Efficiency Project: Post-Construction Performance Report [0:43]

Discussion Summary

Peter Erig and Colleen Fassette of Siemens Smart Infrastructure presented preliminary results from the district's Phase 1 energy efficiency project (district-wide LED lighting, building envelope/weather-stripping work, upgraded energy controls, and new or refurbished windows at Canal School and the high school). The project carries a guaranteed annual savings of $255,000; measured results so far project $279,000 in actual savings. Central Maine Power rate increases since January 2023 (34% higher summer demand charges, a sharp rise in per-kilowatt-hour costs) mean the district would have seen roughly $150,000 in additional utility costs without this project. A forthcoming rooftop solar array at four schools will add further savings; the state is using Westbrook's approach as a model, now being replicated at RSU 13 in Rockland.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentation.

Action Items

None.

Monthly Financial Reports & Capital Improvement Plan Update [17:52]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Mazjanis reviewed routine budget-to-actual reporting; January's elevated 12% spend rate (versus a typical ~8%) reflects a three-paycheck month. Substitute-teacher spending ($64,000 for the period) was flagged as a line to watch. Member Andrea Mancuso asked why Westbrook Middle School's water/sewer budget showed only 19% remaining versus 30–40% at other schools; staff will investigate.

Dr. Lancia reported City Council has given first-reading approval to the bond-fund reallocations previously discussed at the February 11 School Committee meeting (Canal/Congin exterior and bathroom work, Westbrook High School security system and window/door replacement), and described FY27 as an intentional pause from aggressive capital work given limited staff capacity. The district received another Maine Revolving Renovation Fund grant for Canal School this cycle and narrowly missed a second grant for Congin.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational reports.

Action Items

None.

FY27 Budget Proposal (Opening Presentation)

Top-Line Numbers & Why the Increase [33:50]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Lancia and Dr. Mazjanis jointly presented the administration's opening FY27 budget proposal: $58,622,000 (approximate), an increase of $5,271,617.34, or 9.88%, over FY26. The leadership team's initial draft had called for a 13.5% increase at $60.5 million; careful review trimmed about $2 million from that request.

Four main drivers: (1) moving positions off unreliable federal funding — five positions moving from Title I to the general fund ($585,806, the first step of a multi-year transition), plus five special-education Ed Tech IIIs moving off IDEA funding, which also avoids an 18% Maine PERS penalty on federally-funded positions; (2) the new Pre-K program at Canal School, costing $384,864 in local funds for its general-education portion (the special-education portion remains state-funded), partially offset as the roughly $100,000 currently paid to the Opportunity Alliance is removed from the elementary schools' budgets; (3) existing-staff salary/benefit increases (~$2.5 million, reflecting current contracts and a conservatively budgeted 10% health-benefit increase); and (4) new/reorganized positions (~$591,578) plus rising special-education out-of-district placement costs.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentation, opening a multi-week budget review process.

Action Items

None.

New Positions, What's Maintained, and What Was Cut [01:08:50]

Discussion Summary

New or reorganized positions include a nutrition education coordinator (funded entirely within the self-sustaining School Nutrition budget), a cybersecurity-focused network systems specialist, an instructional technology integration specialist, an additional special-education bus aide and van driver, a new gifted-and-talented-model English teacher at the high school, a new CTE Exploratory teacher and cooperative-education instructor at WRVC, a special-education resource teacher and Ed Tech III, and a part-time speech therapist. Not included: a full-time Assistant Director of Special Services for pre-K, and a long-sought curriculum coordinator role, which Dr. Lancia said needs clearer definition before it returns.

Maintained: student/staff ratios and class sizes, all core programs (general ed, special ed, multilingual, unified arts), student support services, athletics, and the music program. Cut from the initial request: the

health-benefits projection, expanded substitute staffing, one bus purchase (leased instead), a four-year rather than three-year iPad lease with no new iPads for seniors, elementary staff device replacement (deferred a year), K-8 IXL software, and one unfilled alternative-learning position.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentation.

Action Items

None.

Revenue & Estimated Taxpayer Impact [01:38:30]

Discussion Summary

General Purpose Aid to Education (ED279) is projected to rise about $2.4 million, but Westbrook's local-vs-state cost share has flipped to 52% local / 48% state (the reverse of a few years ago) as the city's property valuation rises. The district also has far less fund-balance cushion available this year, having already used $700,000 of FY24 carryforward to buy down the FY26 budget. Using preliminary 2025 valuation figures, staff estimated the FY27 mill rate at 9.72 (up from 8.74) — roughly a $336.31 annual increase for a home valued at the city's 2025 average of $341,000, explicitly caveated as a preliminary estimate.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — this was the opening presentation of a multi-week budget review process; cost-center-by-cost-center review continues at upcoming Finance Committee meetings.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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